

that ease your creative process. A couple of these are Effects switch (fx) and the 3D layer switch.

The effects switch is like a kill switch for all the effects in a layer. Over the course of a project, you may end up adding quite a number of effects of to layers or a particular layer. If at some point, you decide that you've overdone it or that a particular layer doesn't really need any effects, you can just switch it off here. It's a much more efficient solution compared to manually expanding each layer and then removing all the effects one by one.

The 3D layer switch is one of the coolest features of After Effects, also featured heavily on the Adobe website and promotions for AE. Once you toggle this on for a particular element (2D), it is converted into a 3D asset. This does not mean that the 2D object appears 3D but rather it becomes much more dynamic and versatile as it gives you the user flexibility to move it along its 3 different axes and even cooler is the fact that you can rotate on its 3 axes. Combining this can give you a host of really cool effects like flipping a coin or spinning a coin or even doing both at the same time if you feel like.

The last couple of features are directly related to time itself unlike most other elements in the timeline panel (it should actually be called the layer-timeline panel as it makes a lot more sense, just like the space-time continuum). The first one is much like the magnifier at the bottom, the first line in the top of the timeline panel (grey line with blue ends) is also like the magnifier. Dragging either end will show you in the line below that where times are usually mentioned in whole numbers – 0:00s, 01s, 02s expand out and show you much more detailed timespans with alphanumeric identifiers replacing them.

Right below these two rows is another grey bar with blue markers in the beginning and end. Modifying these will reduce the preview to a shorter time frame instead of previewing the whole video all at once. This is a feature that has to be specifically lauded as it helps when you want to perfect and continuously improve one particular effect which may not span more than a few seconds. It's completely pointless if you have to replay the whole video every single time in this case.

Lastly, there's a small green bar right below this grey line. This is called the RAM preview line. In basic terms, it's just a buffering bar (like in YouTube). If it's green all the way, then the preview will play without any hiccups. If it's not, then it's going to be a lot less smoother. This is also where the Resolution discussed in the next part comes into play. If there are a lot of layers with a lot of features, then it's going to take a lot of RAM and it's